

Ads in AI: Insights From Real User Behaviour



✦ Ask anything



The new advertising frontier is **already here**.

A new advertising channel has arrived and it's faster, and more intent-rich than anything that's come before it. **460 million people** now discover products inside AI assistants every month.

ChatGPT is growing at 39% year over year. The fastest-growing discovery surface since mobile is already monetized, already competitive, and already rewarding the brands that moved first

This is one of the first reports of its kind. Built on proprietary data from Similarweb Ad Intelligence, it maps the emerging landscape of AI advertising across the three platforms where it's already happening at scale:

- ChatGPT
- Google AI Mode
- AI Overviews.

Who is advertising. What it costs. How it performs. And what the data reveals about a form of user intent that keyword-based systems were never built to read.

**The opportunity is real, the data is here, and the window is open.
This is what the landscape looks like from the inside.**

Ads are live.

On three platforms.

Three platforms are competing for AI ad dollars right now.
Each one targets differently, fires at different moments in the conversation.
Treat them as one channel and you'll misallocate budget.

ChatGPT

~1K

brands active

Sponsored links in chat

\$50K minimum

Google AI Mode

Thousands

brands active

Shopping + text in AI answers

Google Ads infra

AI Overview

100K+

brands active

Product cards from Shopping

Auto from Shopping

Three platforms.

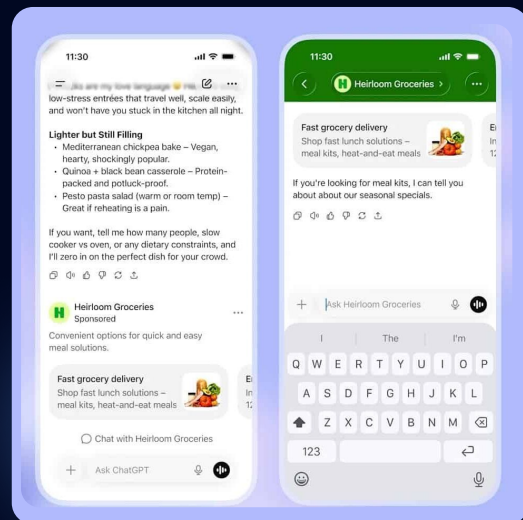
Three completely different models.

	ChatGPT	AI Mode	AI Overview
Targeting	Full conversation context	Query keyword match	Search query
When ads fire	44% Turn 1 56% later in conversation	98.5% Turn 1	Single query
Top brands	HubSpot, Fiverr, Preply, Cursor	eBay, Walmart, Best Buy, Amazon	eBay, Walmart, Temu, Etsy
Ad moment	Exclusive — 1 brand per conversation turn	Shared — multiple ads per response	Shared — carousel of product cards
Creative style	Text + Image	Text + Image / PLA	Text + Image / PLA
Think of it as	Podcast Advertising	Google Shopping 2.0	The Default

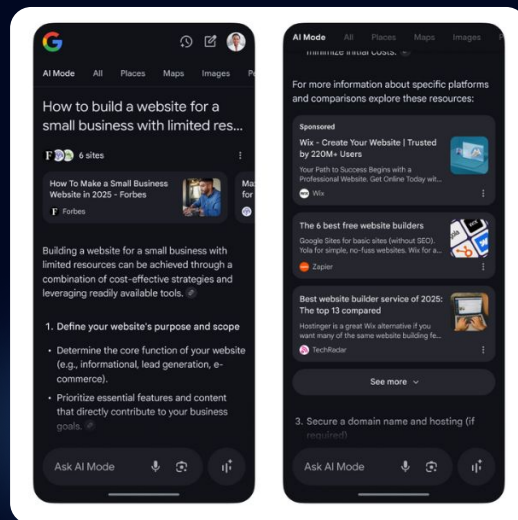
THREE DIFFERENT AD TYPES

Three platforms. Three different ad types.

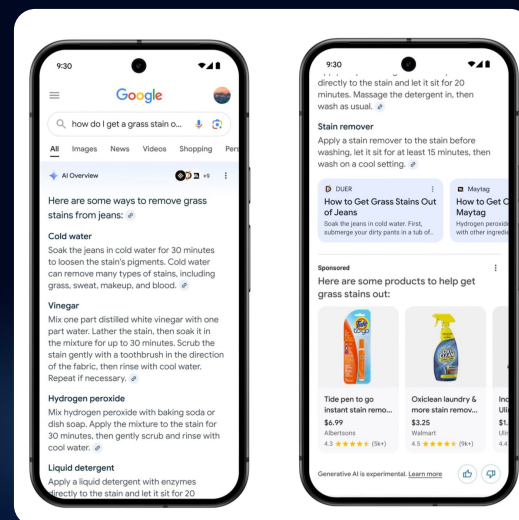
ChatGPT



AI Mode



AI Overview



It reads the conversation, **not the query.**

ChatGPT doesn't match your ad to a keyword. It reads the entire conversation, every turn, every question, every follow-up, and decides which brand belongs in that moment.

A user who never typed "headphones" can end up seeing a headphone ad. The context earned the impression, not the query.

What this changes:

83%

of ad-triggering queries would never have triggered a Google Shopping ad.

These are not "buy now" moments. They're research, planning, comparison, consideration. Only 2% of headlines say "buy now." This is brand advertising wrapped in conversation, not direct response.

Santa Fe, New Mexico—often called "The City Different"—is a captivating blend of history, art, and natural beauty at the foot of the Sangre de Cristo Mountains. As the oldest and highest-elevation state capital in the U.S., founded in 1610, it offers a unique mix of Native American, Spanish, and Anglo cultures.



Pueblo & Pine
Sponsored



These options may help if you're planning a trip to Santa Fe.

Desert Cottages

Expansive residences with desert vistas



Ask ChatGPT



THE CHATGPT AD MOMENT

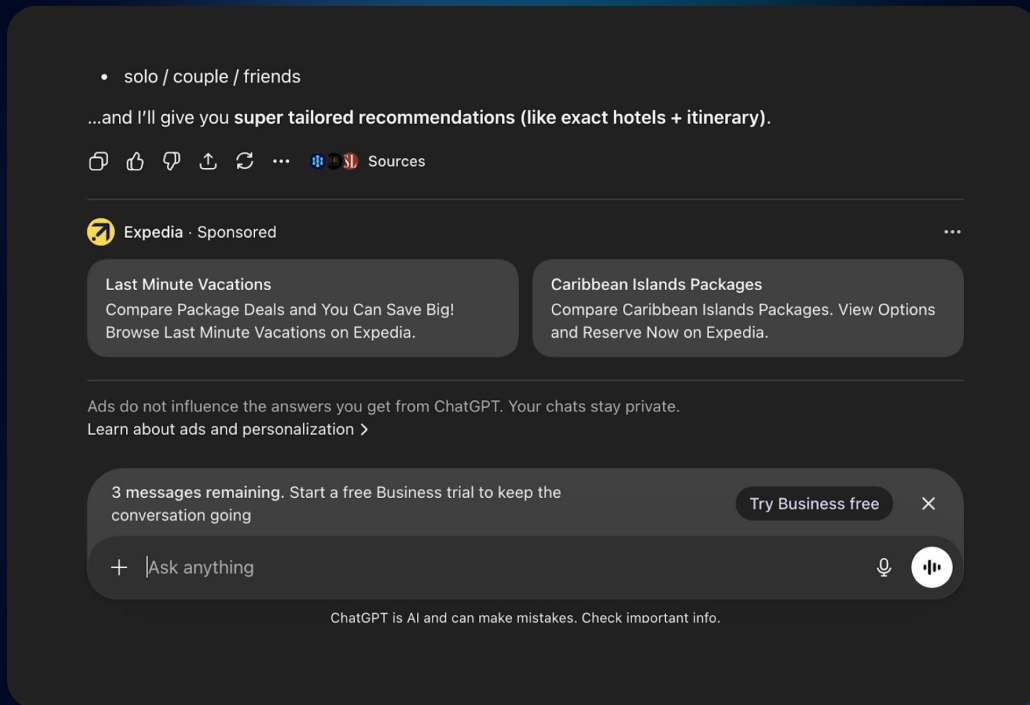
One brand. One turn.
No competition.

Right now, when ChatGPT shows a sponsored result, it shows one.

Yours, or someone else's.

No side rail. No competing cards. No ten blue links. Just a single branded moment with a user who's already deep in the conversation.

This format doesn't exist on Google or Bing, and it's a big opportunity.



THE CHATGPT AD MOMENT

Deeper conversations, longer exposure.

On ChatGPT, the ad doesn't interrupt the conversation.

It becomes part of it, landing inside an exchange the user is already invested in, with four more turns of brand exposure still to come.

	ChatGPT	Google AI Mode
Post-ad continuation	73%	41%
Median conversation	6 turns	1 turn
Avg conversation	17 turns	2.6 turns
Post-ad turns	4 more	1 more

ChatGPT conversations are 6× deeper — more surface area for brand exposure per session.

PERFORMANCE

ChatGPT ad performance so far

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Click-Through Rate Distribution

0.68%	Overall CTR	
0.50%	Median (brand-level)	Half of brands above, half below
1.00%	p75	Top quartile of brands
1.57%	p90	Best-performing brands
5.4%	Peak brand CTR	

Benchmark: Search avg 3-5% | Display 0.35% | Podcast 0.5-1%

Pricing

\$60

Assumed CPM

Meta \$10-15
LinkedIn \$33-65

\$12

Implied CPC

Search \$2-4
Podcast \$15-25

Ad penetration: climbing and cyclical

ChatGPT	
Avg	1.5%
Weekday peak	2.0%
Weekend low	0.8%
Clear weekly cycle: Mon–Thu peak, weekend dip, Monday recovery	

Google AI Mode	
Avg	0.09%
Weekday peak	0.12%
Weekend low	0.07%
15× lower penetration than ChatGPT — but 2.7 ads per conversation vs 1.7 (60% denser)	

Source: Similarweb panel data (Mar 30 – Apr 13).

A NEW MODEL: CONVERSATIONAL INTENT

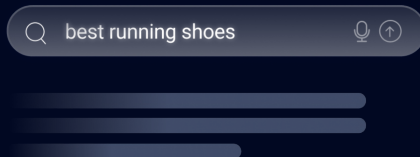
We've measured the data.
Now let's decode it.

Keywords worked when search was simple: user types query, you match it, you win.

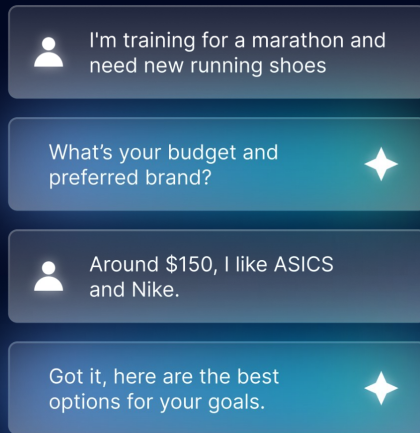
Conversations are different. Intent shifts. Context matters. A single query tells you nothing the whole turn tells you everything.

To understand what's actually happening in ChatGPT, **we built a new model: conversational intent.**

From: Query



To: Multi-turn conversation



We don't track keywords. We track what people are actually trying to do.

In a multi-turn conversation, a single query is never the whole story. Someone who opens with "what are the best running shoes for beginners" is in a completely different mindset than someone who says "I just signed up for a half-marathon, what do I need to start training?" The words overlap. The intent doesn't.

Similarweb has built our conversational intent classification on exactly that distinction. Rather than matching against keywords, our model reads the full arc of a conversation to determine what a user is actually trying to accomplish at the moment an ad fires. The result is a behavioral signal that keyword models simply can't access, one that reflects not just what people typed, but where they are in their decision journey. Every ad impression we measure is classified into one of 8 intent categories:

INF

Informational

COM

Commercial

TSK

Task-Completion

NAV

Navigational

TRX

Transactional

CON

Conversational

ENT

Entertainment

PER

Personal

We read intent at three moments per impression

A single query tells you one thing.
A conversation tells you three.

Moment

What we capture

Opening



What the user came in wanting

Ad moment



What the conversation had become by the time the ad fired

Post-ad

Where the conversation went after

The gap between Opening and Ad Moment is where the commercial opportunity lives.

CONVERSATIONAL INTENT

Here's an **example**

A user opened ChatGPT looking for golf advice. No brand in mind. No intention to buy. Just research.

Ten turns later, they were ready to purchase without ever typing a commercial query.

Conversation:

Turn 1

"What are the best golf irons for mid-handicappers?"
Research. No buying signal.

Turn 10

"Compare Callaway Paradym vs TaylorMade P790 price and reviews"
Still research. But intent has shifted.

The ad

DICK'S Sporting Goods "Golf Club Deals"

Conversations generate intent

46%

of users who opened with zero commercial intent developed buying signals by the time an ad appeared.

69%

of opening intent persists – but new intent layers on top.

AI conversations don't replace intent. They generate it.

**Illustrative examples drawn from anonymized panel data*

Example Conversations · COM: 0 → 3

HubSpot — "Scale Outreach"

Turn 52/70

Opened: "Where are distilled acid oils exported from USA?"

Ad moment: "US buyers of sunflower acid oil, best strategy to reach out"

Market researcher → active seller

Indeed — "Career Advice"

Turn 30/42

Opened: "Help me prepare interview for Admin Assistant"

Ad moment: "Write follow up email"

Interview prep → active job pursuit

Envato — "Unlimited Graphics"

Turn 66/66

Opened: "Having margin issues with the interior of the book"

Ad moment: "Come up with 7 keywords and phrases that sell"

Layout fix → marketing optimization

You can't optimize what you can't see

Every platform gives you your own data. None show you the competitive landscape.

Similarweb's multi-source methodology is the way to see the full picture.

What you can see

Google Ads reports "Top Ads" impressions

ChatGPT Ads Manager shows your campaign data

Shopping feed performance is aggregated

What's still invisible

AI Mode & AI Overview aren't broken out — you don't know which came from AI

No competitor visibility, no share of voice, no category benchmarks

No way to isolate AI Overview placement performance from standard search

NEXT STEPS

Your Takeaway. What can you do right now?

Every platform gives you your own data. None show you the competitive landscape.

Similarweb's multi-source methodology is the way to see the full picture.

ChatGPT

Run a pilot campaign

Apply via OpenAI. \$50K min. Think brand voice in a conversation, not banner copy. This is the new format.

Google AI

Audit your Google Ads account today

Your Shopping and text campaigns are likely already serving in AI Mode and AI Overview, you just can't see it in reporting yet.

similarweb

Track AI ad performance across all 3 platforms

Conversational AI ads insights on Ad Intelligence starting this quarter.

Early movers win categories. Late movers inherit them.

The AI ad era didn't announce itself. It just started. Three platforms are already monetizing conversations at scale, the performance data is stronger than most marketers expect, and the competitive landscape is filling up faster than the reporting can track. Here's what to do with that: three platforms, three different games, know which one you're playing. Your competitors are already in. Find out where.

The brands that move now, that test, measure, and build conversational creative muscle before the window narrows, will set the category patterns that late movers inherit. ChatGPT sits at 1.5% ad penetration today. Pharma, Auto, Insurance are still absent. Your vertical may be wide open. Every new channel starts with low competition and high attention, and this one is moving faster than most. The measurement gap is real, but it's the same gap that creates the opportunity.

Be among the first to close it and shape the patterns every brand in your category will be following in two years. The window is open. It won't stay open.

 **similarweb**  Ad Intelligence

Know before you spend.
Similarweb Ad Intelligence

Contact us

Try it out